

Constituents Angelica root contains a volatile oil (consisting mainly of beta-phellandrene), lactones, and coumarins. An extract of the root has been shown to be anti-inflammatory.

History & Folklore The *British Flora Medica* (1877) reports that “the Laplanders considered this plant as one of the most important productions of the soil ... They are subject to a severe kind of colic, against which the root of angelica is one of their chief remedies.” The stems are candied for culinary use.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Angelica is a warming and tonic remedy, having a role to play in a wide range of illnesses. All parts of the plant will help relieve indigestion, gas, and colic. Angelica can also be useful in cases of poor circulation, as it improves blood flow to the peripheral parts of the body. It is considered a specific treatment for Buerger’s disease, a condition that narrows the arteries of the hands and feet. By improving blood flow and stimulating the coughing up of phlegm, angelica’s warm, tonic properties bring relief from bronchitis and debilitating conditions affecting the chest. For respiratory conditions, the roots are most commonly used, but the stems and seeds may be employed as well.

Caution Do not take as a medicine during pregnancy. Do not confuse with Chinese Angelica.

Self-help Use Stomach spasm, p. 305.

Angelica dahurica (Apiaceae)

Bai Zhi

Description Aromatic perennial growing to 8 ft (2.5 m). Has a hollow stem, large 3-branched leaves, and umbels bearing many white flower heads.

Habitat & Cultivation Grows wild in thickets in China, Japan, Korea, and Russia. Cultivated mainly in central and eastern regions of China.

Part Used Root.

Constituents *Bai zhi* contains a volatile oil and the coumarins imperatorin, marmesin, and phellopterin.

History & Folklore *Bai zhi* is first mentioned in Chinese herbal medicine in the *Divine Husbandman’s Classic* (*Shen’ong Bencaojing*) of the 1st century CE. The famous military physician Zhang Congzheng (1150–1228) classified *bai zhi* as a sweat-inducing herb able to counter harmful external influences on the skin, such as cold, heat, dampness, and dryness.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The pungent, bitter *bai zhi* is used for headaches and aching eyes, nasal congestion, and toothache. Like its cousins angelica (*A. archangelica*, see preceding entry) and dong quai (*A. sinensis*, p. 63), it is warming and tonic, and it is still given for problems attributed

to “damp and cold” conditions, such as sores, boils, and ulcers affecting the skin. *Bai zhi* also appears to be valuable in treating the facial pain of trigeminal neuralgia.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Annona squamosa (Annonaceae)

Custard Apple

Description Tree growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has oblong- to lance-shaped leaves, greenish flowers, and segmented green fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to tropical America and the Caribbean, this herb is cultivated throughout the tropics.

Parts Used Leaves, bark, fruit, seeds.

Constituents Custard apple contains fruit sugars and mucilage.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In the West Indies, the young shoots are used with peppermint (*Mentha x piperita*, p. 114) to relieve colds and chills. In Cuban medicine, the leaves are taken to reduce uric acid levels. The leaves, bark, and unripe fruit are all strongly astringent and are used to treat diarrhea and dysentery. The crushed seeds are mixed with an inert powder and employed as an insecticide.

Research Custard apple has been shown to have antiprotozoal and anthelmintic (worm-repelling) activity.

Anthemis cotula (Lamiaceae)

Mayweed, Stinking Mayweed

Description Annual or perennial resembling German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77). Has slightly hairy stems and large solitary daisy-type flowers. As the name stinking mayweed suggests, this plant has an unpleasant smell and taste.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb commonly grows wild in Europe, the Americas, Australia, New Zealand, and Siberia. The flowers and leaves are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Flowers, leaves.

Constituents Mayweed contains sesquiterpene lactones (including anthecotulide).

History & Folklore In his *Irish Herbal* of 1735, the herbalist K’Eogh states that mayweed is “good for women with the falling down of the womb, if they but wash their feet with a decoction of it.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Although it looks similar to German chamomile, mayweed is far less effective as a medicine. It has been used as an antispasmodic and to induce menstruation, and

was traditionally employed for supposedly hysterical conditions relating to the uterus.

Cautions The whole plant can cause blistering if applied fresh to the skin. Do not take during pregnancy or if breastfeeding.

Anthriscus cerefolium (Apiaceae)

Chervil

Description Annual herb growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has finely grooved stems, opposite leaves, and many small white flowers arranged in compound umbels.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, Asia Minor, Iran, and the Caucasus, chervil grows freely in open areas. It is cultivated throughout the world. The herb is gathered when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Chervil contains a volatile oil, coumarins, and flavonoids.



Chervil is an aromatic herb that plays a role in healing as well as in cooking.